

EMS MEDICAL TERMINOLOGY

Comprehensive Abbreviation Reference

Common Prefixes

Prefix	Meaning	Example
a-/an-	without, not	apnea = without breathing
brady-	slow	bradycardia = slow heart rate
tachy-	fast	tachycardia = fast heart rate
hyper-	above, excessive	hypertension = high blood pressure
hypo-	below, deficient	hypotension = low blood pressure
dys-	difficult, painful	dyspnea = difficulty breathing
poly-	many	polyuria = excessive urination
oligo-	few, scanty	oliguria = decreased urination
hemi-	half	hemiparesis = weakness on one side
para-	beside, near	paraplegia = paralysis of lower limbs
peri-	around	pericardium = sac around heart
sub-	under	subcutaneous = under the skin
supra-	above	supraventricular = above the ventricles
inter-	between	intercostal = between the ribs
intra-	within	intravenous = within the vein
endo-	inside	endotracheal = inside the trachea
exo-	outside	exogenous = originating outside
anti-	against	anticoagulant = against clotting

Common Suffixes

Suffix	Meaning	Example
-itis	inflammation	appendicitis, meningitis
-osis	condition, disease	fibrosis, stenosis
-ectomy	surgical removal	appendectomy, cholecystectomy
-otomy	cutting into	tracheotomy, craniotomy
-ostomy	creating an opening	colostomy, tracheostomy
-plasty	surgical repair	angioplasty, rhinoplasty
-scopy	visual examination	endoscopy, bronchoscopy
-gram	record, image	electrocardiogram, radiogram
-graph	instrument for recording	electrocardiograph
-graphy	process of recording	radiography
-emia	blood condition	hypoglycemia, hyperkalemia
-uria	urine condition	hematuria, dysuria
-pnea	breathing	apnea, tachypnea, dyspnea
-phagia	swallowing	dysphagia
-plegia	paralysis	hemiplegia, quadriplegia
-tocia	labor, delivery	dystocia
-rrhea	flow, discharge	diarrhea
-rrhexis	rupture	angiorrhesis

Body Systems Quick Reference

System	Components	Common Conditions
Cardiovascular	Heart, blood vessels	MI, CHF, DVT, PE, AAA
Respiratory	Lungs, airways	COPD, asthma, pneumonia, PTX
Neurological	Brain, spine, nerves	CVA, TIA, seizure, TBI
Gastrointestinal	Stomach, intestines	GI bleed, appendicitis, bowel obstruction
Musculoskeletal	Muscles, bones	Fracture, sprain, dislocation
Endocrine	Hormones, glands	DKA, hypothyroidism, Addisonian crisis
Renal/Urological	Kidneys, bladder	Renal failure, kidney stones, UTI
Reproductive	Reproductive organs	Ectopic pregnancy, PID, testicular torsion
Integumentary	Skin, hair, nails	Burns, cellulitis, pressure ulcers
Hematologic	Blood, bone marrow	Anemia, sickle cell, leukemia
Immunological	Immune system	Anaphylaxis, lupus, HIV/AIDS

Directional Terms

Term	Meaning
Superior	Toward the head / above
Inferior	Toward the feet / below
Anterior (Ventral)	Front of the body
Posterior (Dorsal)	Back of the body
Medial	Toward the midline
Lateral	Away from the midline
Proximal	Closer to the trunk
Distal	Farther from the trunk
Superficial	Near the surface
Deep	Away from the surface
Supine	Face up, lying on back
Prone	Face down, lying on stomach
Fowler's	Seated upright (90 degrees)
Semi-Fowler's	Partially upright (30-45 degrees)
Trendelenburg	Head down, feet up

DISCLAIMER: Educational purposes only. Not medical advice. Always follow local protocols and medical direction. Verify all clinical information against current evidence-based resources.